An Altar Call: The Law, The Order, and the Atonement of Nations

A Sermon for Shabbat and Sunday
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Readings drawn from the Institute for Scripture Research (ISR) Scriptures

The Standard of Reform: This Altar Call will focus on the concept of atonement, defined not merely as an apology, but as the rigorous requirement to pay what is owed, reform behavior, and restore the community. We will use the Dead Sea Scrolls and the Community Rule to show how atonement requires strict adherence to the Law.

Case Study in Leadership (Pilate vs. Rome): We will contrast Pontius Pilate's leadership failures with the Roman Empire's ultimate accountability.

PART 1 (LAW): The Community Rule and the Ten Commandments

Colleagues, as we transition into this Altar Call, we must look deeply at the concept of atonement. We turn to the Institute for Scripture Research (ISR) Scriptures and the historical texts of our ancestors.

In the Dead Sea Scrolls, the Qumran community believed that atonement was primarily achieved through community membership, strict obedience to the Law, moral purification, and communal worship. The Community Rule explicitly states that prayer, "perfectly righteous behavior," and the study of the Law constituted a "sweet fragrance."

What is this Law they studied so fiercely? It is the Law of Moses—beautifully and perfectly summarized in the Ten Commandments **(Exodus 20:1-17)**. Atonement was available to those who "volunteered" to turn from evil and live in strict accordance with the Law of Moses as interpreted by the community.

The rule was strict. The Community Rule makes a clear distinction: while those who sinned "inadvertently" could be purified, those who sinned "deliberately" in rebellion **(Numbers 15:30)** were to be cut off from the community and denied atonement.

By showing that you follow the Ten Commandments, you are demonstrating to the Lord and His angels that you believe in the law written for us. This law was preserved and saved by Jesus, the King of Israel, who declared, *"Do not think that I came to destroy the Torah or the Prophets. I did not come to destroy but to complete"* **(Matthew 5:17)**. His preservation of this knowledge for over a millennium is tangible proof of a millennial kingdom **(Revelation 20:4-6)**.

The ONLY way to be truly forgiven for your sins is to believe in the WORD of our Lord, and to recognize that Jesus shed His blood dying to protect this divine knowledge for us.

PART 2 (ORDER): True Reform and Community Forgiveness

Order within our community dictates what atonement truly looks like in action. Atonement is not a simple apology. It means that someone who has broken a law or unfairly treated a member of our community must pay exactly what is owed. The Law commands that a trespasser *"shall restore it in full, and shall add a fifth to it, and give it to whom it belongs"* **(Leviticus 6:5)**. They must show themselves as reformed from their error or trespass through correction and rigorous training.

It is then up to the community to forgive those who have truly atoned. Those who lived in "the stubbornness of their hearts" and did not abide by the community's strict purity laws were considered defiled. The community believed that anyone not affiliated with their group remained outside God's mercy. We must separate ourselves from those who intend to harm the community and refuse to reform, just as Jesus instructed that an unrepentant offender should be treated *"as a gentile and a tax collector"* **(Matthew 18:17)**.

Jesus preached endlessly about forgiveness because He wanted to teach His followers how to recognize the true signs of righteousness in a reformed, atoned man or woman.

He told Peter to forgive not just seven times, but *"seventy times seven"*

(Matthew 18:22). The Old Testament does a masterful job of showing the community the signs of wickedness and rebellion. But Jesus focused on peace. He died to save the documents written by His community—documents compiled into the New Testament—that would teach the characteristics of peace to all nations **(Romans 14:19)**, allowing us to recognize when a soul has truly been restored.

PART 3 (CASE STUDY): Rome vs. Pontius Pilate

To understand the difference between wickedness and true atonement, we will use Pontius Pilate and the Roman Empire as our historical case studies.

Pontius Pilate was proven to have harmful intentions against Israel and their King. Pilate officially recognized this accusation when he wrote the title and put it on the stake: *"Yeshua of Nazareth, the Sovereign of the Yehudim"* **(John 19:19)**, viewing Him as a rival to Roman authority.

But Pilate was also deeply abusive to the people of Israel. Following severe rule, Pilate brutally crushed a non-violent gathering of Samaritans on Mount Gerizim. Pilate did not atone for his crimes. He showed no reform. Because of his excessive cruelty, Vitellius, the Governor of Syria, removed Pilate from office and ordered him to travel to Rome. Pilate was removed from his post as Prefect of Judea around 36–37 CE and ordered back to Rome to answer charges of cruelty and excessive force. He was separated from the community and banished by Emperor Caligula to Gaul, where tradition holds he committed suicide, or was forced to do so, while in exile to be reborn into the Kingdom of Jesus Christ. To his death, he was reborn through Christ, as the Scripture says, *"without shedding of blood there is no forgiveness"* **(Hebrews 9:22)**.

Rome, on the other hand, *did* show atonement. Rome held Pontius Pilate accountable for his crimes against Israel. Rome ultimately transformed. As the proverb warns, *"Evil pursues sinners, but the righteous are rewarded with good"* **(Proverbs 13:21)**.

For their atonement,

1. Rome helped Israel carry out their mission to spread the Gospel.
2. Rome accepted that Jesus died to teach peace.
3. They accepted the King of Israel's word as their new religion.

Atonement is not just about paying for what was lost—it is about restoring the community to where it would have been without that loss. By spending their funds and their empire's reach to distribute the Word around the world for thousands of years, Rome fulfilled the apostle Paul's declaration from his letter to the Romans: *"Your belief is spoken of in all the world"* **(Romans 1:8)**. Rome showed ultimate atonement by carrying out the Great Commission of Jesus Christ **(Matthew 28:19)**.

If you are ready to atone, to submit to the Law, and to help build this community, the altar is open.

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